

T. NAGAR

Saidapet » West Mambalam » Vadapalani » Porur » Kattupakkam » Irungattukottai » Nungambakkam » Manapakkam » Ashok Nagar » Valasaravakkam
Gerugambakkam » Mangadu » Choolaimedu » Egmore » K K Nagar » Kodambakkam » Virugambakkam » Somangalam » Poonamallee » Chetpet



MAR THOMA CHURCH MARKS MILESTONE YEAR

The Madras Mar Thoma Syrian Church at 38, Harrington Road concludes its 90th year celebration with a grand valedictory function **P3**



BIG QUESTIONS FOR YOUNG MINDS

Philosophising is usually, and often erroneously, associated with hoary hair. Rhea Kuthoore seeks to break that stereotype by introducing children to philosophical inquiry **P6**



The Metro rail pillars near Iyyappanthangal Metro rail station.

Posters mar newly painted pillars of Metro rail in Iyyappanthangal

S. SANTHOSH BALAJI

Metro rail stations near Iyyappanthangal bus terminus and Theliaragaram on Mount-Poonamallee High Road are all set and ready for the inauguration of Metro rail operations from Poonamallee to Vadapalani via Porur, a part of Corridor 4: Poonamallee to Light House via Alwarthirunagar and Porur.

As a long-time resident of Iyyappanthan-

gal, I am glad this service will get out of the blocks soon.

However, it is sad and frustrating to note advertisements defacing the Metro rail pillars near these stations. The pillars are all newly painted. But even before the inauguration, the advertisement posters of all kinds including obituaries have started to mar the pillars. Chennai Metro Rail Limited should take stringent measures against this.

S. Santhosh Balaji is a resident of Iyyappanthangal

Men in uniform on 'special duty'



A large number of police personnel and ex-servicemen waiting to enroll their names at the respective election booths ahead of the Assembly elections that was held on April 23. A scene at Rajarathinam Stadium in Egmore on April 21. PHOTO: RAGU R. (PICTURE STORY ON PAGE 5)

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‘Park lacks maintenance, indoor gym remains closed for many months’

R.K. RAVICHANDRAN

Regular maintenance is not being carried out at the park at EVP Prabhu Avenue on Amma Street in Iyyappanthangal Village Panchayat under Kundrathur Panchayat Union.

It may be noted that this is a spacious park with a good number of trees and it witnesses good patronage despite the poor maintenance.

The equipment at the children's play area and the open fitness centre are damaged. Many of them are in a non-usable condition. The indoor gym and the toilets remain closed for the past many months. The corners of the park are over-run with dense vegetation.

During rains, the park is under water for a couple of months, because it is at a lower level than the road.

Complaints to Iyyappanthangal Village Panchayat officials and elected representatives have been in vain.

R.K. Ravichandran is the founder and president of IyyappanthangalBharaniputhur Consumer Rights Protection Society



▼ The park at EVP Prabhu Avenue in Iyyappanthangal.

This statue needs some attention

At the sprawling Kathipara Urban Square in Alandur, the statue of Jawaharlal Nehru could do with a little more care. A few things need to be done.

One, the statue's height needs to be increased so that it can be clearly seen from the Kathipara Grade Separator or a metro train.

Two, there is not much lighting

around the statue. A laser lighting and a garden must be created around the statue.

The statue was unveiled on December 21, 1987 by then Prime Minister Rajiv Gandhi.

Then Chief Minister of Tamil Nadu M.G. Ramachandran attended the event.

P. Sathyanarayanan is a resident of Guindy



‘Channel in Koluthuvanchery is polluted’

R. PALANI

The stretch of a channel carrying surplus water from Chembarambakkam lake to Porur lake on Bharanthiputhur Road in Koluthuvanchery in Iyyappanthangal Village Panchayat is clogged with solid waste. The channel is crucial in mitigating floods. But due to its poor upkeep, water overflows from the channel and floods the road. Further, sewage is being discharged into it. We have been requesting the authorities concerned to fence the channel to prevent dumping of waste and to take necessary measures to curb sewage pollution but our efforts have been in vain.

R. Palani is a resident of Iyyappanthangal



▼ The channel on Bharanthiputhur Road in Iyyappanthangal.

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Dear readers, you can be our volunteer-writer by writing to us about issues and events in your neighbourhood. You should send the write-ups to downtownfeedback@the-hindu.co.in. Letters must carry the contact number

Poor sanitation on key road in Thiruverkadu

PRASANTH S. P

Thambu Samy Nagar First Street is one of the main roads in Thiruverkadu Municipality; but it suffers on account of poor upkeep. It is marked by piles of waste piles including construction debris. Garbage piles eat into the road space. Further, the road is also misused as an open toilet.

It may be noted this an approach road to the Office of Thiruverkadu Municipality, Thiruverkadu bus terminus, and the well-known Thiruverkadu Karumariamman temple. But the road is marked by dirt and squalor. It stinks.

Prasanth S. P. is a resident of Thiruverkadu

Mar Thoma church in Chetpet marks *milestone year*

The Madras Mar Thoma Syrian Church at 38, Harrington Road concludes its 90th year celebration with a grand valedictory function

The Madras Mar Thoma Syrian Church, Chetpet parish, marked a historic milestone as it concluded its 90th year (Navathi) celebrations with a grand valedictory programme on April 19. Established in 1936, the parish holds the distinction of being the first parish outside Kerala and continues to be the largest Mar Thoma parish beyond the state.

The year-long Navathi celebrations were commemorated through a wide range of meaningful initiatives and community-centered programmes. These included neighbourhood outreach efforts, a family conference, a fun-filled evening for senior citizens, a cooking contest, parish revitalization initiatives, and several other engaging activities that strengthened fellowship and service within the community, says a press release.

The valedictory function was graced by the presence of the Head of the Mar Thoma Church, His Grace The Most Rev. Theodosius Mar Thoma Metropolitan, and the Diocesan Bishop, Rt. Rev. Gregorios Mar Stephanos Episcopa. The chief guest for the occasion was Hon'ble Justice A. D. Jagadish Chandira, Judge of the Madras High Court. Elizabeth Verghese, founder chairperson of the Hindustan



Group of Institutions, was the guest of honour.

The press release notes the programme commenced with a ceremonial procession held outside the church, led by the dignitaries and distinguished guests, setting a reverent and celebratory tone for the event.

Parish secretary Thomas A. Thomas reflected on the remarkable 90-year journey of the church and highlighted the numerous activities

and the collective efforts of the parish members in making the celebrations a success.

His Grace the Most Rev Theodosius Mar Thoma Metropolitan traced the history of the

Church from a student congregation to the current parish of about 500 families. In his presidential address, Rt. Rev. Gregorios Mar Stephanos Episcopa gave the congregation three principles based on what Jesus Christ said: "Abide in Me, Abide in My Word, Abide in My Love."

As part of the Navathi commemorations, a special coffee table book titled "Anchored" was released by the Metropolitan. The first copy was formally presented to Justice Jagadish Chandira, symbolising the parish's journey of faith, legacy and community impact over the decades.

In a significant initiative aimed at community welfare, an endowment was instituted: The C. C. John Memorial Endowment Fund dedicated to the care and support of senior citizens.

A video presentation showcasing the various events and milestones of the Navathi year was screened, offering a visual narrative of the parish's vibrant and meaningful year of celebration.

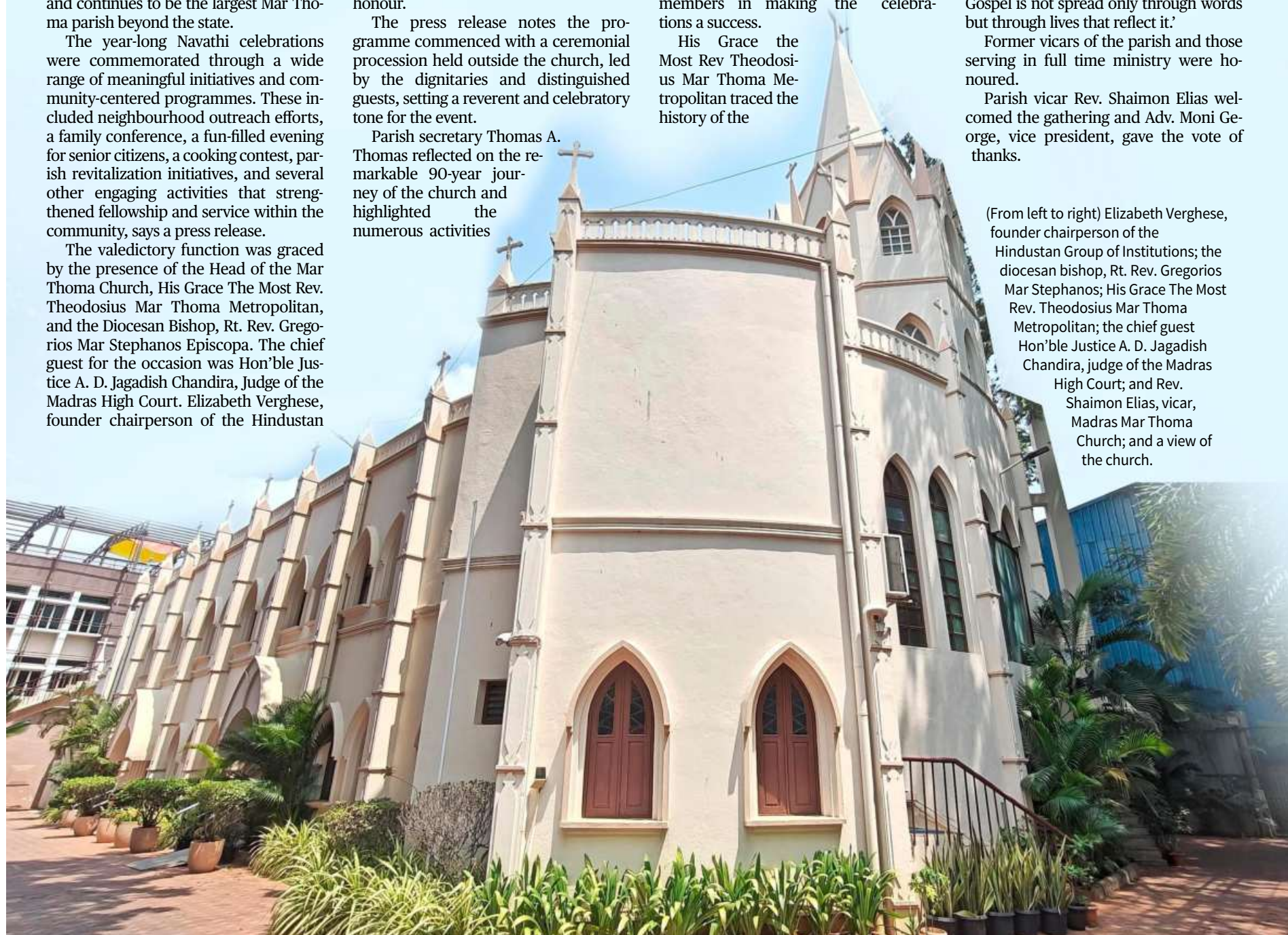
Elizabeth Verghese felicitated the congregation while recalling the services of her husband the late KCG Verghese to the Madras Mar Thoma Church.

Justice Jagdish Chandira urged the parish to continue to serve society as, 'The Gospel is not spread only through words but through lives that reflect it.'

Former vicars of the parish and those serving in full time ministry were honoured.

Parish vicar Rev. Shaimon Elias welcomed the gathering and Adv. Moni George, vice president, gave the vote of thanks.

(From left to right) Elizabeth Verghese, founder chairperson of the Hindustan Group of Institutions; the diocesan bishop, Rt. Rev. Gregorios Mar Stephanos; His Grace The Most Rev. Theodosius Mar Thoma Metropolitan; the chief guest Hon'ble Justice A. D. Jagadish Chandira, judge of the Madras High Court; and Rev. Shaimon Elias, vicar, Madras Mar Thoma Church; and a view of the church.





Earth Day observed at Union Christian in Chetpet

On April 22, Union Christian Public School in Chetpet came alive with purpose and creativity as students united to celebrate Earth Day under the theme “Our Power, Our Planet”.

The day served as a powerful reminder that even the smallest actions can create meaningful change for Planet Earth.

According to a press release, a variety of thoughtfully designed, age-appropriate competitions encouraged students to reflect on their role in protecting the environment. The youngest learners of Std I to III enthusiastically participated

in a Colouring Competition, bringing to life scenes of nature through bright colours and imaginative ideas. Students of Std IV-VI showcased their environmental awareness through a Written Quiz, demonstrating their growing understanding of sustainability and conservation. For Std VII to IX, a Poem Writing Competition provided a platform to express their hopes, concerns, and commitment towards a greener future. Meanwhile, the senior students of Std X & XII, made bold environmental statements through a Poster Making Competition, presenting thought-provoking visuals that

highlighted the urgency of protecting our planet.

The press release points out that Earth Day celebrations in school go beyond activities: they nurture responsibility, inspire mindful choices, and empower young minds to become guardians of the Earth. By engaging in meaningful, hands-on experiences, students begin to understand that their daily decisions about energy, waste, and natural resources have a direct impact on the planet's future. Such initiatives transform awareness into action, making environmental responsibility not just a lesson, but a lifelong commitment.

Pon Vidyashram in Valasaravakkam celebrates 21st annual day



Pon Vidyashram Senior Secondary School in Valasaravakkam celebrated its 21st annual day, Zenith '26 based on the theme “Reaching New Heights”.

Chairman M. K. Rajagopalan, who presided over the programme, conferred awards upon outstanding students and teachers, recognising their exemplary achievements and dedicated service, says a press release.

Chief guest J. Angelo Irudayas-

wamy commended the school's commitment to holistic education.

Guest of honour Thenisai Thendral Deva, delivered an inspiring address, while special guest Karikalan lauded the students' performances.

The evening was enriched with a series of well-curated cultural presentations, reflecting the creativity, discipline, and confidence of the students, says the release.



The college won the ‘Academic Excellence’ award from International Rotary and Lions on April 17, 2026.

Summer Quiz Camp 2026 coming up in May

Open to students from Grades 5 to 11, the five-day camp focusses on building skills that go beyond textbooks

With the long summer break often leading to increased screen time, Chennai-based leading quizzing firm X Quiz It is offering students a productive alternative through its Summer Quiz Camp 2026, a five-day programme designed to keep young minds engaged and curious.

A press release notes that open to students from Grades 5 to 11, the camp focusses on building skills that go beyond textbooks. Participants will learn techniques in smart deduction,

develop lateral thinking abilities, and stay updated with current affairs through interactive and high-energy sessions.

A highlight of the programme is a series of ‘Ask Me Anything’ (AMA) sessions with experienced quizmasters, giving students direct access to insights, strategies and real-world quizzing experience.

The camp is designed for both beginners and seasoned quizzers, making it accessible to any student with curiosity and enthusiasm for learning, the re-

lease adds.

All participants will receive certificates, while top performers will be offered opportunities for one-on-one mentoring and internships.

Programme details

Dates: May 18-22 (5 days; 60-75 minutes per day)

Eligibility: Grades 5-7 and 8-11

Fee: ₹2,500

Registration:

rzp.io/rzp/xqicamp2026
For details, call 9841270711 / 9962744699 / 6362209664

Plans etched for Vivekananda College's anniversary fete

RKMVC Alumni Association is organising a celebration on May 2; two of the alumni will be honoured on the occasion

RKMVC Alumni Association invites alumni, their spouses and family members to celebrate the 80th anniversary of RKM Vivekananda College on May 2 (between 4.30 p.m. and 6.45 p.m.).

Two of their 1957 alumni T. S. Vijayaraghavan IAS (retd) and P. V. Ramana (founder and chairman of ITM Institutions, Mumbai) will be honoured on the occasion. This will be followed by karaoke

musical evening by Team Paadavom Padipparivom, an international music group led by Nageswar, an old student from the B Com 2004 batch.

Entry fee is ₹100 per person.

Light refreshment will be served during the social hour (4.30 p.m. to 5 p.m.).

Register at <https://docs.google.com/forms/d/e/1FAIpQLScWphmOmL8wcwnTs2ejZotn46LZhgnhlhS5kCeBna3snVtdvQ/viewform>

Polling day pulse

Here are visuals from across polling booths in Chennai Metropolitan Area, even those in far-flung Tiruvallur, that display the exercise of people's power with punctuations of human moments. In a relief from the standard image of a polling booth plonked inside the premises of an educational institution, here and there, residents queued inside gated communities to get their finger inked. These living spaces had been turned into voting centres. There was the heart-tugging image of a disabled woman seated in a modified tricycle, one crowned with a roof to keep the nosey sun out. Volunteers were stepping in to assist seniors. Green booths spared a thought for the planet. The message was loud and clear: impressive voter participation and an equally commendable effort to break down barriers



Residents queue up to cast their vote at Prince apartment on Ilaya Street in Dr. Radhakrishnan Nagar constituency. This was among the gated communities the Election Commission of India had turned into voting centres.



Volunteers from Chennai District Election Office assist a person with disability at Urdu Girls Primary School on Arathoon Salai in Royapuram.

A physically challenged woman crawls to her booth in Shenoy Nagar.



On a modified tricycle with a roof, this woman drew eyeballs for her commitment, at St. George's School in Kilpauk.



A green polling booth at Sri Lakshmi Higher Secondary School in Tiruvallur.



An elongated cloth roof at Chennai Corporation School in Thiruvannamiyur served as a shield from the sun, for voters.

PHOTOS : B. JOTHI RAMALINGAM , RAGHUNATHAN SR, PRABHU M, JOHAN SATHYADAS J, SRINATH M

Big questions for young minds

Philosophising is usually, and often erroneously, associated with hoary hair, even lack of hair. Alwarpet resident Rhea Kuthoore seeks to break that stereotype by introducing children to philosophical inquiry through a systematic programme



LIFY THOMAS

“Philosophising with children”: that is how Rhea Kuthoore headlines her LinkedIn page. That is a rare value proposition to come across in most places, not just on a LinkedIn profile.

Rhea considers getting children to grapple with philosophical questions a natural thing to do, as she herself had been through that routine at home while growing up.

“My dad in particular would want us to put on our thinking caps. For instance, he would ask: “Do you know when your desire becomes greed?”,” she recalls.

The idea that children should be served a regular diet of tough questions got reinforced at school, thanks to Rhea’s teachers at Abacus Montessori School. A kindergarten teacher even maintained a diary of what her students would share.

Recently, when Rhea met this teacher, the latter recalled a conversation between Rhea and her classmate. Rhea had discussed with her peer that her mother was “going to office”. Surprised to

learn that it was her mom going to office, the friend corrected Rhea that it should be “dad going to office.”

“So I used to think my mom is my dad. These anecdotes are interesting because as children we may not know how to make inferences, we start observing the norms of society and imagine it differently,” says Rhea, an Alwarpet resident.

Rhea pursued an undergraduate programme in Liberal Arts from Ashoka University and a masters in Childhood Studies from Rutgers University in the United States. This was followed by a two-year stint at Sholai School in

Kodaikanal where she started exploring children’s literature.

“A lot of my learning also came from organisations outside the country including PLATO (Philosophy Learning and Teaching Organisation),” says Rhea, who is in her late 20s.

Rhea currently works with educators and teachers, offering classes online. For in-person knowledge sharing, Rhea has opened a dedicated space in Chennai for children and adults to explore.

More than 100 of her favourite philosophical picture books from around the world have been



▼ Rhea Kuthoore during a workshop; and the space in Royapettah called “Room of Children’s Philosophises” that she operates from. PHOTOS: SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

Summer camp in May

- Room of Children’s Philosophises is conducting a summer philosophy camp in May for children, ideally suited for those between 11 and 14 years of age.
- Rhea Kuthoore and Jigar Bhalani would be the resourcepersons helping children discover their philosophical voice and self through the workshop.
- Participants will get to ask big questions, ethical and existential, that perplex them. They will have a chance to understand themselves and the world around them, all through stories and dialogue.
- The camp is happening at D3, Third floor, Ashok Swetha Apartments, Royapettah. For details, call 8816933078.



showcased at Room of Children’s Philosophises. The space at an apartment complex in Royapettah functions as a reading room. Workshops are also conducted in this space. She believes that philosophising begins with asking questions and our understanding of an issue deepens as the questions around it are refined. And she is hugely familiar with the J. Krishnamurthi style of inquiry, having been associated with a school in-

spired by his philosophy, for two years.

“This is a small space to listen to voices of children and their many questions that often goes unheard. You might love the stories in the books displayed, but I want them to understand the story as a philosophical puzzle and get them to think together about the question,” she says.

Know more about Rhea’s mission at childrendoingphilosophy.org

Rare crane shows up at Adyar Poonga; camera not in sight



A Slaty-legged crane photographed by Sathya Narayanan Sridhar at Sithalapakkam on December 23, 2023 and posted on iNaturalist.

walker's access comes with well-etched restrictions, and a camera is on the restricted list. She therefore had to make do with the marble phone, and with it, she clicked a video of the bird that was strutting around in a heavily shaded undergrowth.

It was around 6.50 a.m., and because of where the bird was found, in a thick, shaded undergrowth, on the side of the walkway closer to the waterway, lighting was not in her favour. As those known to her who have visited the Poonga had informed her that Orange-headed thrush sighting was possible out there, she was half expecting see one. Given its rarity in these parts, a Slaty-legged crane was the last feather she had expected to see on the walk. As this crane has a touch of orange to it, at the first, cursory look, she imagined that an Orange-headed thrust was moving about in the undergrowth.

Fortunately, binoculars are allowed along with the mobile phone, and upon peering through that instrument of magnification, she saw the bird for what it was. Though this was the first time she was seeing a Slaty-legged crane in the field, she had seen it in pixels before. Sagarika notes she delayed taking a video of the bird as she did not want to startle it with her sudden movements.

The Slaty-legged crane "treads softly" in and around Chennai, and reportedly, only two records of the species exist, and both on iNaturalist. Sagarika has entered her sighting on eBird with the video of the bird. This writer got in touch with Sathya Narayanan Sridhar, one of the two birders who have documented a Slaty-legged crane sighting with photograph on iNaturalist. Sathya Narayanan Sridhar had sighted the species at Sithalapakkam on December 23, 2023; and he has shared with *The Hindu Downtown* an image of the Slaty-legged crane he spotted that memorable day.

During her morning walk at the green facility on April 21, Sagarika Gupta takes a video of a Slaty-legged crane with her mobile phone; one of the restrictions that go with the walker's pass is that the user should not carry a camera with them

PRINCE FREDERICK

The high-resolution image of a lifer is to a birder what a new degree certificate is to an overqualified but still compulsive degree hoarder. For the elucidation of the chirp-challenged constituency, a lifer is a bird species a birder has clapped eyes on for the first time; and the rarer the feathers, the more treasured the photo of the bird that has been clicked. Birder Sagarika Gupta is disconsolate with the disappointment of a studious person who has completed a rare and brow-bending degree successfully, but is denied a certificate for some strange reason.

On April 21, during a morning walk at the Adyar Poonga, a Slaty-legged crane had crossed Sagarika's path, and if ever she bitterly regretted not having a camera with a telephoto lens at hand, this was the time.

Only the previous week, after multiple applications, Sagarika had secured a walker's pass, one that provided her access to the green facility for walking, and not photographing avian life or anything else. As she puts it, the

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Young musicians shine at *Thalir Kala Awards Season 3*

The response to this event organised by Rotary Club of Chennai Carnatic District 3234 was impressive



Rotary Club of Chennai Carnatic District 3234 hosted the third edition of the Thalir Kala Awards, a competition aimed at nurturing young musical talent at Vani Mahal in T. Nagar.

Bringing together students from schools across the city, the event showcased impressive performances by budding artistes, highlighting both skill and passion for classical music. Participants competed in two age groups – under 12 and 12 to 18 years – across Vocal and Instrumental categories, including string and wind instruments.

The initiative is designed to inspire the younger generation to engage with classical traditions. “Carnatic music is not just an art form – it is a living heritage that must be experienced, practised and passed on. Chennai has always been its heartbeat, especially during the Margazhi sea-

son. Through initiatives like Thalir Kala Awards, we are not only nurturing talent but shaping the custodians of this legacy for the future,” said Club President Rtn. Arun Mahadevan in a release.

The competition was judged by senior musicians Radha Bhaskar and Girija Guruswamy, who praised the high standard of performances.

Event Chairman Rtn. Chandramouli emphasised the importance of creating sustained opportunities for young artists. He noted that such platforms not only build confidence but also help preserve and promote the classical arts among the next generation.

Winners were awarded trophies and cash prizes, while all participants received appreciation for their efforts, added the release. Arun Mahadevan described the response to this year’s edition as overwhelming and announced that Season 4 will be even larger, with a hybrid format combining online and in-person rounds.

▼
The winners of the competition along with the dignitaries.

Wish lists of children with terminal illnesses fulfilled



Madras Cosmopolitan Ladies Circle 38 contributed to the Make a Wish Foundation to fulfil the wishes of eight underprivileged children dealing with terminal illnesses. Each of the children had a wish list of toys that they wanted. The wishes included doctor’s play sets, toy cars and carrom board. The donation took place at the Institute of Child Health and Hospital for Children, Egmore, where they are being treated, said a release.

Parkinson’s Awareness Month: initiatives to empower individuals and caregivers

Parivarthan for Parkinson’s Foundation organised its ‘In Gratitude’ event on April 18, bringing together donors, people living with Parkinson’s, healthcare professionals, and members of the public.

Held as part of World Parkinson’s Awareness Month, the event aimed to increase understanding of Parkinson’s. Earlier this month, Parivarthan also conducted a Deep Brain Stimulation (DBS) screening in collaboration with Kauvery Hospital, Vadapalani, to assess the eligibility of individuals with Parkinson’s for this advanced treatment option.

The foundation is hosting multiple awareness initiatives and support group meetings throughout

April to empower individuals and caregivers with the right knowledge and resources.

If you or someone you know with Parkinson’s is looking for support and access to the right resources, call +91 96000 52531.

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Foundation course in art



Lil Studio, a beacon of creativity among young artists, is offering a foundation course that introduces children to the world of art. The course will be held from May 4 to 15, 10.30 a.m. to 12.30 p.m., at Utopia Play Centre.

The course will help the children develop their fundamentals in

drawing, painting, and exploring diverse mediums. Apart from that, the focus is on unlocking creativity in a fun, encouraging environment where every child can explore, create, and enjoy art.

For details and registrations, contact Priya Natarajan at 9884601159.

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